

## Barking up the right tree

**SALICYLIC ACID** is a substance that helps **reduce pain** in the body's nerve endings. This means it's good at relieving such **common complaints** as headaches, swellings, and muscle aches. Some plants, such as meadowsweet and the bark of the willow tree, **are rich in salicylic acid**. Willow bark was used as a remedy for fever in ancient Greece, more than two thousand years ago.



Willow bark chips were used as an herbal remedy.

## How it changed

Aspirin is now the most widely used drug for pain relief in the world. Around 100 billion tablets are taken every year.

the world

Aspirin was first sold as a powder in tins.



# Aspirin

The handy, HUMBLE PILL that gives fevers and headaches the old heave-ho

## Mixing it up

Salicylic acid **TASTED AWFUL** and could cause vomiting and stomach pain, so various chemists in the 19th century worked to find ways to **remove its bad side effects**.

In 1897, chemists in Germany produced **acetylsalicylic acid (ASA)**, which caused fewer side effects but was still an effective pain reliever. German chemical company Friedrich Bayer & Co. began selling ASA in 1899 under the brand name **ASPIRIN**.

Plastic bottle often comes with a childproof lid.

## Wonder drug

In 1900, aspirin was first sold as tablets that **dissolve in water**, the first medicine to be sold in this form. It was taken to ease **HEADACHES AND FEVERS**, and by people who suffered from rheumatism to reduce pain in their joints. More recent research suggests that aspirin can help **prevent blood clotting** and may even have a role in fighting Alzheimer's disease and certain cancers.



Tablets contain a set dose of aspirin mixed with corn starch and water.